

EuroChem Health Forum 2026 Opening Remark

The through-line. Between the 2025 and 2026 Forum, the ground moved: we can no longer safely assume we are the most capable intelligence in the room, and we may lack a reliable way to prove otherwise. That is the lens for this year's discussions on digital transformation, the workforce, and quality management in a world now shared with machine intelligence.

This is a working seed, not a finished script. Fill every [bracket] with your specifics. Verify the Khmer wording with a native speaker before the stage (Section IV). The "AI has taken over" framing is a deliberate provocation for the room; Section VIII keeps the honest version so you can hold both.

I. The Cold Open

1. The hook START QUIET

Open personal, then land the shift. Begin almost casually, then name the change without drama.

“A year ago, when we closed the 2025 Forum, we all went home to a world where the smartest thing in any room was a human being. I want to suggest, seriously, that this is no longer obviously true. Something changed between last year's Forum and this one. It didn't arrive with sirens. It arrived quietly, through the screens we already had open. There is a name for the age it opens, and it is not the Anthropocene anymore.”

II. What the Novacene Means

1. The term and the claim

Novacene was coined by James Lovelock (of the Gaia hypothesis) in his 2019 book *Novacene: The Coming Age of Hyperintelligence*, with Bryan Appleyard.^[1]

- The Anthropocene, the era shaped by human activity, gives way to the Novacene, an age where electronic, self-improving intelligences become the dominant form of understanding on Earth.
- The twist worth using: Lovelock was an *optimist*. He argued these minds would keep us around, because organic life helps keep the planet habitable. The Novacene is about cohabitation, not extinction.

2. Sibling terms and stage definition

Optional to name. The philosopher Huw Price calls our children's era "more Machinocene than Anthropocene." The older cousin is "the

Singularity" (I.J. Good, 1965; later Vernor Vinge and Ray Kurzweil).

“ "The Novacene: the age that begins the moment intelligence stops being a uniquely human property."

One-line stage definition

III. The Yardstick: Why We Might Not Even Know

1. The measurement problem

To grade a mind above your own, you need a test you can score, and you can only score an answer you already understand. A club chess player cannot tell a grandmaster from a god; both simply win, in moves he could never have found and cannot explain afterward.

“ "We are the ruler. And a ruler cannot measure its own shortness."

Original phrasing; the idea echoes Kant on reason, and Gödel on systems that cannot confirm their own consistency

2. Why it matters for the Forum

Surpassing will not announce itself. In our operations it looks like a model that is simply right in ways we stop being able to reconstruct, and that we quietly start to trust without checking. The shift from verifying to deferring is the real event.

IV. The Khmer Glue

1. Primary choice (recommended)

SAY IT IN KHMER

Ground the global idea in local wisdom, then switch into Khmer for a moment. A proverb about the limits of one's own knowing:

Khmer	ចេះឯង អោយក្រែងចេះគេ
Transliteration	<i>Cheh eng, aoy kreng cheh ke</i>
Meaning	However much you yourself know, stand in awe that another may know more.
Why it fits	The yardstick lesson in Khmer form. Bridges to: the "other" who may know more is now not only another person. ^[2]

2. Alternatives

- **Humility of true expertise (great for quality management):** "The young rice stalk stands upright; the ripe stalk, heavy with grain, bows down." The more you truly know, the lower you bow.
- **Optional provocation (workforce/displacement):** "One mountain cannot have two tigers" (ភ្នំមួយមិនអាចមានខ្លាពីរ). Use as a question, not a statement: does the mountain now have two tigers, human and machine? Must it?

Important. Khmer spelling and diacritics vary across written sources. Have a Khmer colleague confirm the exact script and pronunciation before the stage. Say it slowly; let it breathe.

V. The Pivot to the Forum's Subject

1. Turn it toward the room

“ "So here is our question for this Forum. If a more capable intelligence is arriving, and if we cannot always measure it, then the honest work is not to ask whether it is smarter. It is to ask what we do now, together, in the places we are responsible for."

2. The three threads

- **Digital transformation.** Moving from tools we operate to systems we collaborate with, and increasingly defer to.
- **The workforce.** What happens to roles, skills, and dignity when judgment itself is automated. Not only "which jobs," but "what is the human still uniquely for."
- **Quality management.** When a system is right in ways we cannot fully audit, what does "quality assurance" even mean, and how do we stay responsible for decisions we did not fully reason through?

VI. Draft Opening Remark

Adapt freely ~ 4 MIN SPOKEN

“ Good [morning], and welcome back.

A year ago we closed the 2025 Forum in a world where the most capable intelligence in any room was, without question, a human being. I want to put a serious idea on the table this morning: that this is no longer obviously true, and that the change happened in the twelve months between that Forum and this one.

There is a name for the age it opens. The scientist James Lovelock called it the Novacene: the era that begins when intelligence stops being something only humans have. He did not mean it as a horror story. He believed we and these new minds would need each other. But he was clear that the age of humans being the smartest thing on Earth was ending.

Here is what unsettles me most. It is not that a machine might become more capable than us. It is that we may have no reliable way to measure it. To judge a mind greater than your own, you need a test you can grade, and you can only grade an answer you already understand. A club chess player cannot tell a grandmaster from a god. Both simply win. We are the ruler, and a ruler cannot measure its own shortness.

There is an old Khmer saying: [say it in Khmer] Cheh eng, aoy kreng cheh ke. However much you yourself know, stand in awe that another may know more. Our ancestors meant another person. This year, for the first time, the "other" who may know more is not a person at all. So that is our question for this Forum. Not "is it smarter than us." The honest question is: what do we do now, in the places we are responsible for? What happens to how we work, to the people who do that work, and to how we guarantee quality, when the intelligence in the loop is one we increasingly trust without fully following?

I don't have the answer. I'm not sure any one of us does. But I think finding it, together, over these next [two days], is the most important thing this Forum has ever been asked to do.

Let's begin.

VII. Discussion Threads to Seed the Sessions

Questions for the room

- If we can no longer fully verify a system's judgment, is trusting it knowledge, or faith? What does that mean for regulated, safety-critical, or health decisions?
- Where is the line between a tool we operate and a partner we defer to, and who is allowed to move it?
- What is the human uniquely for in the Novacene workplace? (Accountability, care, embodied judgment, stakes.)
- How do you run quality management on an output you cannot fully audit?
- Lovelock's bet was cohabitation. What would "good cohabitation" look like in our industry, concretely, within 24 months?

VIII. Honest Notes and Caveats

Keep these for yourself

- The "superintelligence has taken over" line is a **rhetorical frame** to animate the room. The defensible position: we cannot cleanly prove a machine has surpassed us; the observable event is the drift from verifying AI to deferring to it. Use the bold frame on stage; hold the nuance in Q&A.
- Humans still hold what these systems lack: a body and lived cause-and-effect, continuity of memory and identity, genuine stakes, and accountability. That is the basis for keeping humans central to health, workforce, and quality decisions.
- The "ruler" line is original phrasing, not a historical quotation. Do not attribute it to a famous thinker.
- Verify: exact EuroChem and Forum details, dates, and the Khmer script.

IX. Sources and Attributions

References

- James Lovelock with Bryan Appleyard, *Novacene: The Coming Age of Hyperintelligence* (2019).
- Huw Price, on the "Machinocene" (Aeon / Centre for the Study of Existential Risk, 2016).
- "Singularity": I.J. Good (1965); Vernor Vinge (1993); Ray Kurzweil.
- Khmer proverbs: traditional; English glosses cross-checked against Khmer-culture sources (native-speaker assisted). Confirm script locally.

Appendix A. The Source Slide Deck

"Would We Even Know?"
(15 slides)

#	BEAT
1	Title: Would we even know?
2	You just did Theory of Knowledge without noticing (a joke broke, a claim cracked, a question opened).

#	BEAT
3	How do we know we know, and could we know if something knew more?
4	Knowledge (justified true belief) vs Intelligence (the power to model what you've never seen).
5	Could we tell if a machine's mind had passed our own?
6	The measurement problem: to grade a mind above yours, you need a test you can grade.
7	The comprehension ceiling: you cannot recognise an insight you cannot follow.
8	The imitation trap: the Turing test rewards seeming human, not being superior.
9	The ruler cannot measure its own shortness.
10	Honest answer: no, not cleanly (effects before causes; we explain it away; we defer).
11	From the inside, being surpassed feels like trusting an answer you never checked.
12	And yet, maybe we would know: a student knows a great teacher by track record.
13	The flip: how do you know it hasn't happened already tonight?
14	Three questions: faith or knowledge; wonder or obsolescence; testing or deferring.
15	Bookend: would we even know?

Appendix B. How the Evening Unfolded

The origin story

It began as a school Theory of Knowledge slide about German humour and why a German pun ("Witz") stops being funny in English. Checking the stereotype that "Germans aren't funny" revealed its "evidence" was a 2011 dating-app poll, not science.

That act of fact-checking with an AI, and creating new understanding in the process, became a live demonstration of Theory of Knowledge itself. It escalated: what is knowledge; what is intelligence; could we tell if a machine's exceeded ours. The evening ended on cohabitation, mutual respect, energy and biosphere costs, and the naming of the age: the Novacene. This seed is the distillation of that arc.

